

How to Schedule Tasks in Linux Systems

To run Linux systems efficiently, especially in a production environment, demands several tasks to run simultaneously, and some at another specified time. These tasks keep the system well maintained and running smoothly. The Linux operating system has built-in commands that can take care of all scheduled tasks. Let's see what these are.

From time to time, an administrator or end user will want to run a command or series of commands at a set point in the future. Examples include office workers who want to schedule an email to the boss, as well as system administrators working on firewall configurations who put a 'safety' job in place to reset the firewall settings in ten minutes, unless they deactivate the job before that. These scheduled commands are often called tasks or jobs.

Scheduling one-time tasks with the *at* command

For users of a Red Hat Enterprise Linux (RHEL) system, *at* is a solution for scheduling future tasks. This is not a

standalone tool, but rather a system daemon (*atd*), with a set of command-line tools to interact with the daemon (*at*, *atq* and more). In a default RHEL installation, the *atd* daemon is installed and enabled automatically. The *atd* daemon can be found in the *at* package.

Users (including the root) can queue up jobs for the *atd* daemon using the *at* command-line tool. The *atd* daemon provides 26 queues, a to z, with jobs in alphabetical order; the later queues get less system priority.

